

B2 First for Schools Writing Paper Part 1

Aims of the lesson	▪ to raise awareness of what students need to do for the compulsory Part 1 question ▪ to give students the opportunity to plan and write a Part 1 answer then compare their answer with a model
Time needed	60 minutes
Materials required	▪ Students worksheets 1 and 2 (one for each student) ▪ Sample Task ▪ Model answer

Procedure

1. Tell students that they're going to look at the Part 1 task from the B2 First for Schools Writing Paper. Give out **Student's worksheet 1** and let students work in pairs to read through the questions and have a guess at the answers from questions 1 to 8.
2. After two minutes when the students seem to have finished give out the **Sample task**. Students continue to work in pairs to complete the worksheet. Go through the answers up to, but not including, question 10 (see **Answer key**).
3. Before you go through the answer to question 10 draw a table on the board:

Good things	Bad things
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When asking for students ideas write them in the appropriate column so that you build up a list of all the good things and bad things on the board.

4. When you have got all the ideas about the good and bad points play hangman with the word 'plan'. Ask the class if they always write a plan when they write and stress how important it is to do so, even if it takes just 3 minutes at the start. Ask the students what the best number of paragraphs for a part one answer is; the answer is **4**. Then elicit how students could structure their essays by boarding the paragraph numbers and asking students to give you their ideas.

One way of structuring an essay like this is to do:

Paragraph 1	Introduction
Paragraph 2	good points
Paragraph 3	bad points
Paragraph 4	Conclusion

5. Give out **Student's worksheet 2** and ask students to write their plan for the essay, thinking about the points they are going to include in paragraph 2 and 3 (remembering to include the two points from the question and at least one of their own ideas). Monitor and help students.
6. Now ask students to look at the sentences on **Student's worksheet 2** (Exercise 2). They need to decide which paragraph each of the sentences comes from. Get them to write a letter (A-D) next to each sentence depending on which paragraph they think it comes from. Students compare their answers (see **Answer key**)
7. Now students look at the sample question again and using their plan they write an essay. Set a time limit for this of say 20-30 minutes.
8. When they have finished tell them they are going to check what they have written. Before they start ask them what they are going to check for.

Possible answers:

- *Have they included all the points?*
 - *Have they made any silly mistakes?*
 - *Can they **add** any nice words: adverbs like 'extremely', for example?*
 - *Can they change any boring words like 'good' into something that will impress the examiner?*
9. When students have finished their essay they can swap with a partner and give feedback on each other's essays. Explain that when giving feedback it is nice to give maybe three pieces of feedback like this:
positive feedback / negative feedback / positive feedback
Let students read the model answer. Get feedback on how the model answer differs to the students' answers. How would they do their essays differently next time? How is the sample answer organised? What has the writer used to organise the ideas in a logical way?

Answer key

Worksheet 1

1. In the exam, do you have to do this question?
Yes, it's compulsory
2. How many words do you have to write?
140 – 190 words. Students often ask what happens if they write too much. Tell them that the examiner will draw a line after the word limit and pay most attention to what is before. The student will not fail if they write too much, but will lose points because the word limit is enough to answer the question effectively and that if they are writing too much, they are probably going off topic or waffling.
3. How much time do you have?
About 40 minutes – half of the 80 minute total
4. Do you have time to write a plan?
Yes, a couple of minutes to write a basic structure and some ideas is very important.
5. Who are you writing the essay for?
Your teacher
6. How many ideas must you write about?
At least three
7. Is it a more formal or informal piece of writing?
Essays are formal pieces of writing and tell students it is very important that they remember to use formal linking words: Firstly, Secondly, Finally; Furthermore, In addition, Moreover; However, Although; In conclusion, To sum up. There are plenty of activities practising these in most coursebooks, pay extra attention to them.
8. Should you write your answer in rough first and then rewrite it?
This is a matter for individual students: some seem to be able to do it easily in the time; others have more problems. It is something they need to discover for themselves.

9. Which two ideas must you include?
having a parent as a teacher
making friends
10. You need to provide the third idea yourself. Can you think of one good thing and a bad thing?
good things – *more choice in what you want to study, one-to-one teaching*
bad things – *having the same teacher all the time, being in the same environment*

Worksheet 2 – Exercise 2

1. C
2. D
3. A
4. B
5. C
6. B
7. A
8. C (see note)

Note: Tell the class that number 8 **isn't** suitable for an essay. Ask the class what the problem is. The problem is that the use of exclamation marks in essays is much too informal. Remind them that essays are academic pieces of writing written for a teacher or university lecturer and that sentences like this are too emotional. Ask the class to change the sentence to make it more suitable. Possible alternative: '*The question of whether the parent is qualified and knows how to teach is also important.*'

Note: This is a good chance to focus on one or two organising words as in question 7 in Task 1.

Student's worksheet 1

Look at the Part 1 task and answer the following questions:

1. In the exam, do you have to do this question?
2. How many words do you have to write?
3. How much time do you have?
4. Do you have time to write a plan?
5. Who are you writing the essay for?
6. How many ideas must you write about?
7. Is it a more formal or informal piece of writing?
8. Should you write your answer in rough first and then rewrite it?
9. Which two ideas must you include?
10. You need to provide the third idea yourself. Can you think of one good thing and a bad thing?

Student's worksheet 2

A. Introduction	
B. Good things	
C. Bad things	
D. Conclusion	

Exercise 2

Look at the following expressions and decide which paragraph they come from – write a letter (**A–D**) depending on which paragraph you think the text comes from.

1. However, there are a number of negative points
2. To conclude, I feel that studying at home may work for some children
3. Nowadays more and more parents are choosing to educate their children in their own homes
4. They will be different to other children and that could be an advantage.
5. Furthermore the child may get lonely without his friends around him.
6. Firstly, there are definitely advantages for children who are taught in this way.
7. It is a well-known fact that there are parents who want to provide their children's education for them.
8. What if the parent doesn't know how to teach!

Sample task

Writing • Part 1

You **must** answer this question. Write your answer in **140 – 190** words in an appropriate style **on the separate answer sheet**.

- 1 In your English class you have been talking about education. Now your English teacher has asked you to write an essay for homework.

Write your essay using **all** the notes and giving reasons for your point of view.

Some parents teach their children at home rather than sending them to school. Is this a good or a bad thing for the children?
Notes Write about:
1. having a parent as a teacher 2. making friends 3. (your own idea)

Model answer

Nowadays more and more parents are choosing to educate their children in their own homes rather than sending them to school, but is this a good thing to do?

There are definitely advantages for children who are taught in this way. Firstly, they are being taught by their parent, so the teacher has a very good idea of what the child needs to study. In addition, they will have one-to-one attention so will not have to compete with other students when they have a question.

However, there are definitely things that a student studying at home will miss out on. Having the same teacher may mean that subjects are always taught in the same way and this could be boring. Another negative point is that there is no way that students can have the same social life if they study at home. They won't see as many friends on a daily basis and they will always be in the same place.

To conclude, I feel that studying at home may work for some children, but it is something that needs to be thought about very carefully.

186 words